

The history of Africa, *told through its names.*

EthniAfrica answers one question: **where do Africa's names come from?** The names of peoples, countries, languages, language families and family names; next, the names of places, customs and words. This is onomastics, combined with etymology. For each name, the site shows the name a people gives itself and the names others gave it, side by side, with every source labelled. Free, open source, built for the phone.

PEOPLE

**Peul, Fulbe,
Pël**

LANGUAGE

Lingala

COUNTRY

Côte d'Ivoire

LANGUAGE FAMILY

Bantu

FAMILY NAME

Traoré

Who named whom, when, and why? Every name keeps the trace of an encounter between peoples.

The problem

There is no unified digital source for searching Africa's history through its names. People make do with Wikipedia and search engines, language catalogues, name-meaning sites with no sources, DNA tests or the media. Nothing brings it all together, or shows the links between peoples.

Above all, Africa is seen **within its national borders**: borders mostly drawn less than 140 years ago, independences barely more than 60 years old. The history before them is rarely taught: people have to find it for themselves.

What sets us apart

- **One angle: the history of the name.** Tracing a name crosses politics, economics, culture and religion. Names reveal what is hidden: peoples that grew from the same branch, or from occupational guilds.
- **Transmitters, not researchers.** We carry on the work of historians and linguists and add oral tradition to it, following the method of UNESCO's *General History of Africa* (vol. I, *Methodology and African Prehistory*, ed. Joseph Ki-Zerbo).
- **A search engine for names:** every piece of information is shown with its source, graded on three levels: official, referenced, unverified.
- **Oral tradition on an equal footing,** identified by its carrier and place, published with their consent.
- **Social media as the front door:** short formats and video, because people read less and watch more.
- **Participation:** readers propose, a small team validates.
- **Free and reusable:** the site and the data under CC BY-SA 4.0, with a public API.
- **A corpus already built:** 770 people records, 807 family names and 54 countries, and 19 volumes of the *General History of Africa* mapped to the corpus chapter by chapter.

First month: an audience found

The social accounts launched in early September 2026. The figures below date from 8 October 2026.

459,600

Facebook views in 4 weeks
(10 Sept. – 7 Oct.), 92% from
non-followers

247,300

Instagram views in 30 days;
2,896 followers

13,500

new follows of the Facebook
page over the same period

4 min

average visit on the site, 3.9
pages per visit

Add TikTok (98,200 views in 28 days, 666 followers) and YouTube (15,900 views in 28 days, 169 subscribers). On the site, 391 unique visitors in 30 days, counted only when they accept audience measurement: a floor, not a total. In the last week measured, search engines and ChatGPT brought 48 of 81 visitors: the site's answers are already being found through search and AI assistants.

Who it serves

- **The French-speaking African diaspora**, then English- and Spanish-speaking: half of measured visitors are in France.
- **The Caribbean and Haitian diasporas**, whose names and memories of origin lead back to African peoples.
- **The continent**: Côte d'Ivoire, Mali and Guinea are the most engaged audiences, on the site and on social media.
- **Researchers, teachers and cultural projects** who need a sourced starting point they can cite and reuse.

In two to three years

- **A habit**: looking up a name on EthniAfrica when wondering where one's people or family name comes from.
- **A cited reference** for researchers and cultural projects.
- **A team** of contributors who propose and validate, so the project no longer rests on one person.
- **A wider scope**, extended to the diasporas and to Creoles.

What we are looking for: €52,700 over 12 months

EthniAfrica is an **independent project incubated by the Big Emotion agency**, carried today by one person, supported by a few part-time volunteers. We are looking for **patrons, grants and institutional or cultural partners** to turn it into a team.

A full-time developer based in West Africa	€15,000
200 sourced and verified records, paid per deliverable, by region: one people and its neighbours	€9,000
A six-week field trip to Dakar, Abidjan and Accra (estimate, to be confirmed with quotes)	€10,000
Production tools for two people, hosting and domains	€7,600
30 oral accounts collected with their carriers' consent, transcribed and documented	€2,400
Expense allowance for social media moderation	€1,800
Contingency (15%)	€6,900

Total

€52,700

The team we aim for. Paid: a developer. Expenses covered: social media moderation. Trained volunteers: checking sources and data on the site, research for publications. Payment goes to verified deliverables, not to hours.

The project stays free and open, carries no advertising, and rules out any partnership with ancestry DNA services.